



FOLKLORE FINDER

FIELD GUIDE SERIES

FIELD GUIDE No.1

ARTHURIAN BRITAIN

LEGENDS · SIGHTINGS · HISTORY · LOCATIONS



A companion to the Folklore Finder Atlas

Arthurian Britain

The legend of Arthur is rooted in real landscape long before it reached the page. Hills where he is said to sleep, caves that hide his knights, stones marking battles and the lakes that swallowed Excalibur are scattered from Cornwall to the Scottish Lowlands, woven through Welsh tradition and the older Brythonic past from which the cycle grew.

The earliest Arthurian material appears in Welsh and Latin sources — Y Gododdin, the Historia Brittonum, and later Geoffrey of Monmouth's Historia Regum Britanniae — centuries before the French romances that gave the cycle Lancelot, the Grail and much of its familiar shape. Because those early sources are sparse on geography, local tradition filled the gaps: almost every region of Britain eventually claimed a hill, cave or battlefield as genuinely Arthur's, and many of those claims are now folklore in their own right, independent of anything in the medieval texts.

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12 PAGES

PDF format



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Where the legends are found

A map of Great Britain and Ireland showing the distribution of 25 sampling locations. The locations are marked with red dots, each surrounded by a white circle. A north arrow is located in the top left corner.

Folklore Finder Field Guide

How to know one when you meet it

The tradition is remarkably consistent across the islands. These are the marks that recur — the grammar of the black dog.

Eyes like coals

Burning eyes — red, yellow, or 'the size of saucers' — are the surest mark. To meet that gaze was, in most tellings, to be marked for a death within the year.

Unnatural size

Larger than any living dog; 'big as a calf' is the phrase used from Norfolk to the Highlands. Sheer size is what sets the spectral hound apart from a stray.

Silence & vanishing

It makes little sound and leaves no track. It falls into step beside you, then is simply gone — most often at a boundary: a gate, a bridge, a stile.

Thresholds & crossroads

Black dogs keep to in-between places — parish bounds, old roads, lychgates and crossroads — the very ground where the living and the dead were thought to meet.

Chains & fire

A dragging chain, a reek of sulphur, or a body wreathed in flame mark the more demonic hounds, especially in the tales of the south-west.

Omen or guardian?

Not every black dog brings death. Some, like the church grim, guard consecrated ground; others walk a lone traveller safely home. Read the errand, not just the beast.

Alderley Edge

CHESHIRE



The Story

Alderley Edge is a wooded sandstone escarpment in Cheshire, riddled with old copper mines and crowned by the most famous Cheshire legend of all — the tale of the Wizard and the sleeping knights. In the story a farmer from nearby Mobberley was crossing the Edge on his way to sell a fine white mare at Macclesfield market when an old man in a long robe stopped him and offered to buy the horse on the spot. The farmer, sure of a better price at market, refused and went on his way. But not a soul at the fair would buy the mare, and as evening fell the farmer returned across the Edge to find the old man waiting, as if he had known all along. The stranger led him to a great rock, touched it, and bid iron gates swing open where there had been only stone. Within lay a vast cavern, and there slept a company of armed knights, each beside a milk-white horse — all but one. The old man, who was a wizard (later tellings name him Merlin), explained that the sleeping host would one day ride out to save England in her darkest hour, and that they lacked only one last horse: the farmer's mare. He paid in old gold from heaps of treasure in the cave, the farmer fled in terror, and when he looked back the gates had vanished into solid rock and were never found again. The legend, popularised in the 19th century and later woven into Alan Garner's novels, belongs to the widespread British family of 'king under the hill' stories — Arthur and his knights waiting in enchanted sleep beneath the land. At Alderley Edge the tale is anchored to a real and atmospheric place of caves and hidden workings, where the Wizard's Well still bears a carved face and the inscription said to mark where the old man appeared.

"A sandstone escarpment in Cheshire haunted by the legend of a sleeping king."

AT A GLANCE

REGION
Cheshire

TYPE
Place

ALSO KNOWN AS
—

MOTIFS
horse, white, haunting,
hill-figure, arthurian

READ THE FULL LEGEND
folklorefinder.uk/legends/alderley-edge

Avalon

SOMERSET



The Story

Avalon makes its first appearance in Geoffrey of Monmouth's *Historia Regum Britanniae*, completed around 1136. Here Geoffrey records that after Arthur's defeat at the Battle of Camlann, the mortally wounded king was carried to the island of Avalon for his wounds to be healed. Geoffrey elaborated in the *Vita Merlini* (c.1150), calling it 'Insula Pomorum' — the Isle of Apples — and describing it as a fortunate island far in the Atlantic, ruled by nine enchantresses, the greatest of whom was Morgan, Arthur's half-sister and a skilled healer. The name Avalon derives from the Celtic root *aballo (apple), cognate with the Welsh afal and the Old Irish aball; Geoffrey was adapting an existing Celtic concept of a blessed island of the dead reached by sea, related to the Irish Tír na nÓg and the tradition of Emain Ablach ('Emhain of the Apple Trees'), the island realm of the sea god Manannán mac Lir. The Glastonbury connection was made decisively in 1191, when monks at Glastonbury Abbey claimed to have unearthed, in their graveyard, a stone slab inscribed 'Hic iacet sepultus inclytus rex Arthurus' — Here lies buried the renowned King Arthur. Glastonbury sits on a natural hill that was once nearly surrounded by the Somerset marshes and could genuinely be described as an island; the Welsh name for Glastonbury, Ynys Wydryn (the Isle of Glass), was conveniently suggestive of Avalon. Modern archaeological consensus holds that the discovery was a fabrication by the monks, who needed funds to rebuild the abbey after a catastrophic fire in 1184. King Henry II, who had political interest in promoting Arthur as permanently dead rather than a sleeping king awaiting return, may have encouraged the story. The 'once and future king' tradition — that Arthur does not die but sleeps in Avalon, waiting to return when Britain needs him most — was current in Welsh and Breton poetry before Geoffrey's account and proved far more resilient than the Glastonbury grave. Thomas Malory's *Morte*

AT A GLANCE

REGION
Somerset

TYPE
Place

ALSO KNOWN AS
—

MOTIFS
island, battle, arthurian, healing, celtic

READ THE FULL LEGEND
folklorefinder.uk/legends/avalon

Bossiney Castle

CORNWALL

The Story

Bossiney, near Tintagel on the north coast of Cornwall, is a small place with a great Arthurian legend, centred on Bossiney Mound — a grassy, man-made motte that was once the heart of a Norman castle and earlier earthworks, set in the very heart of Cornwall's Arthurian country. While the castle that crowned it is long gone, the mound is the focus of one of the most evocative of all the local Arthur traditions. Legend holds that King Arthur's golden Round Table lies buried beneath Bossiney Mound — and that once each year, at midnight on Midsummer Eve, the great table rises up out of the ground to stand glittering in the moonlight, throwing a flash of light into the sky before it sinks again into the earth. The yearly rising is said to herald, or to await, the prophesied return of Arthur and his knights from their long sleep, ready to come again in Britain's hour of need. The tradition belongs to the wider Cornish landscape of Arthurian belief around Tintagel — the headland of his conception, Merlin's Cave below it — and to the great British myth of the sleeping king who is not dead but only waiting. In a Christianised version of the tale, the golden Round Table will rise at the end of the world to be carried up to heaven, the saints seated round it. With its buried golden table and its midsummer rising, Bossiney Mound keeps the promise of Arthur's return fixed to a quiet green hillock on the Cornish coast.

"A Cornish site tied to Arthurian and local tradition around Tintagel country."

AT A GLANCE

REGION
Cornwall

TYPE
Place

ALSO KNOWN AS
—

MOTIFS
castle, vanishing, arthurian

READ THE FULL LEGEND
folklorefinder.uk/legends/bossiney-castle

Caerleon

CAERLEON, NEWPORT, WALES

The Story

Caerleon, on the River Usk near Newport in south Wales, was one of the three great legionary fortresses of Roman Britain — Isca, base of the Second Augustan Legion — and the impressive remains of its amphitheatre, baths and walls survive to this day. It is this Roman grandeur, half-ruined and brooding in the landscape, that drew the place deep into Arthurian legend, above all through Geoffrey of Monmouth, the 12th-century writer who did so much to shape the myth of King Arthur. Geoffrey made Caerleon one of Arthur's principal courts and the site of his most splendid plenary assembly, a place of crowned kings, archbishops and knights gathered in magnificence — turning the real Roman city into a capital of the legendary realm. Later tradition went further: the great oval of the Roman amphitheatre, sunk and grassed-over, came to be identified by local belief as King Arthur's Round Table itself, the ring of earth where his knights had gathered. Caerleon thus became one of the leading candidates, alongside Camelot, for the heart of Arthur's kingdom. The fusion of solid Roman archaeology with Arthurian romance has given Caerleon a special place in the British imagination, and it later drew Romantic and Victorian writers — Tennyson among them stayed there while working on his *Arthurian Idylls of the King*. As a place where the tangible ruins of Rome are overlaid with the dream of Arthur's court and Round Table, Caerleon is a gateway between recorded history and legend, the Roman city remembered as the seat of the once and future king.

“A Roman fortress town deeply folded into Arthurian tradition.”

AT A GLANCE

REGION

Caerleon, Newport, Wales

TYPE

Place

ALSO KNOWN AS

—

MOTIFS

castle, love, arthurian

READ THE FULL LEGEND

folklorefinder.uk/legends/caerleon

Walk the ground the stories haunt

Caerleon

CAERLEON, NEWPORT, WALES

A Roman fortress town deeply folded into Arthurian tradition. Geoffrey of Monmouth made it one of Arthur's chief courts, turning its ruins into a gateway between Roman Britain and medieval romance.

folklorefinder.uk/legends/caerleon



Craig y Ddinas

PONTNEDDFECHAN, NEATH, WALES

A limestone crag in the Vale of Neath beneath which King Arthur and his knights sleep in an enchanted cave, surrounded by gold and silver, awaiting the day Britain calls them back. A Welsh traveller once stumbled in, accidentally struck a bell, and was beaten and cast out — never finding the entrance again.

folklorefinder.uk/legends/craig-y-ddinas

Dinas Emrys

BEDDGELERT, GWYNEDD

At Dinas Emrys, legend says King Vortigern's walls collapsed each night until the young Merlin revealed two dragons fighting beneath the hill. The red dragon's victory over the white became an enduring symbol of Wales.

folklorefinder.uk/legends/dinas-emrys



Fionn mac Cumhaill

COUNTY ANTRIM, NORTHERN IRELAND

Leader of the Fianna — Ireland's warrior band — who gained the gift of all wisdom by accidentally tasting the Salmon of Knowledge, then spent his life hunting, fighting, and loving across a legendary Ireland. He sleeps in a cave beneath Ireland, ready to return when needed.

folklorefinder.uk/legends/fionn-mac-cumhaill

EXPLORER TIP

Many sites are wild, remote or private. Stay safe, respect the land and follow local guidance.

Dusk and the dead of night, and most of all the turning points of the year — the old fire-festivals, and the nights around a funeral or a storm.

Lonely lanes and green roads, lychgates and churchyards, parish boundaries, bridges and the coast path.
Black dogs keep to edges.

The eyes, the size, the sound (or silence), and where it appears and vanishes. Mark the exact spot — the tradition is rooted in real places.

Never trespass; ask permission on private land. Don't go alone after dark, tell someone your route, and leave every site as you found it.

Date · Place · What you saw

How the legends took shape

The earliest Arthurian material appears in Welsh and Latin sources — Y Gododdin, the *Historia Brittonum*, and later Geoffrey of Monmouth's *Historia Regum Britanniae* — centuries before the French romances that gave the cycle Lancelot, the Grail and much of its familiar shape. Because those early sources are sparse on geography, local tradition filled the gaps: almost every region of Britain eventually claimed a hill, cave or battlefield as genuinely Arthur's, and many of those claims are now folklore in their own right, independent of anything in the medieval texts.

SIMILAR CREATURES

Black dogs shade into a wider family of spectral hounds and guardian beasts — the barghest of the north, the Manx moddey dhoo, the Welsh gwyllgi, the church grim set to guard consecrated ground, and the Cù Sith of the Highlands. Most share the same core: a great black dog, burning eyes, and an errand between this world and the next.

Track your discoveries

Tick off each legend as you track it down.

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Alderley Edge <i>Cheshire</i> | ☐ Mordred <i>East Lothian</i> |
| ☐ Avalon <i>Somerset</i> | ☐ Morgan le Fay <i>Tintagel</i> |
| ☐ Bossiney Castle <i>Cornwall</i> | ☐ Nanteos Cup <i>Ceredigion</i> |
| ☐ Caerleon <i>Caerleon</i> | ☐ Pwyll, Prince of Dyfed <i>Narberth</i> |
| ☐ Camelot <i>Somerset</i> | ☐ Rhitta Gawr <i>Snowdonia</i> |
| ☐ Castle Downs, Cornwall <i>Cornwall</i> | ☐ Sir Bedivere <i>Somerset</i> |
| ☐ Chalice Well <i>Somerset</i> | ☐ Sir Galahad <i>Somerset</i> |
| ☐ Craig y Ddinas <i>Pontneddfechan</i> | ☐ Sir Kay <i>Gwynedd</i> |
| ☐ Dinas Emrys <i>Beddgelert</i> | ☐ Sir Percival <i>Denbighshire</i> |
| ☐ Dozmary Pool <i>Cornwall</i> | ☐ Stonehenge <i>Wiltshire</i> |
| ☐ Fionn mac Cumhaill <i>County Antrim</i> | ☐ The Green Knight <i>Britain</i> |
| ☐ Gawain <i>Scotland / Arthurian Britain</i> | ☐ The Lady of the Lake <i>Llyn Llydaw</i> |
| ☐ Glastonbury Tor <i>Somerset</i> | ☐ The Loe <i>Cornwall</i> |
| ☐ Guinevere's Grave at Meigle <i>Meigle</i> | ☐ Tintagel <i>Cornwall</i> |
| ☐ King Arthur <i>Somerset</i> | ☐ Tintagel Castle <i>Cornwall</i> |
| ☐ Lancelot <i>Arthurian Britain</i> | ☐ Twrch Trwyth <i>Porth Clais</i> |
| ☐ Llyn Barfog <i>Aberdyfi</i> | ☐ Uther Pendragon and Pendragon Castle |
| ☐ Mabon ap Modron <i>Wales</i> | ☐ Waun Mawn <i>Preseli Hills</i> |
| ☐ Martin Mere <i>Lancashire</i> | ☐ Winchester Round Table <i>Winchester Great Hall</i> |
| ☐ Merlin <i>Wales & Britain</i> | ☐ Y Ddraig Goch <i>Snowdonia</i> |
| ☐ Merlin's Cave <i>Cornwall</i> | ☐ Ynys Enlli <i>Llyn Peninsula</i> |
| ☐ Merlin's Oak <i>Carmarthen</i> | ☐ Ysbaddaden <i>North Wales</i> |



ABOUT THE SERIES

The Folklore Finder Field Guide Series explores the creatures, places and people of British and Irish folklore — one theme at a time. Each guide is a companion to the interactive atlas at folklorefinder.uk.

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